

Charles Harless

Software Engineering Manager

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Summary

Experienced Software Engineering Manager with over 15 years of experience driving mission critical technology platforms at organizations including Disney, Amazon, and NBC Universal. Launched Disney Movies Anywhere streaming platform, enhanced agility within engineering teams, and managed distributed teams working on building enterprise-level media platforms. Effectively translated ambiguous business priorities to engineering plans, drove efficiency through prioritization, and scaled engineers to leadership positions.

Career Highlights

- Launched Disney Movies Anywhere with 3.5M mobile downloads and 20M+ users within the first month
- Reduced engineering backlog by 75% in 30 days at Brightcove through a prioritization framework
- Improved deployment frequency by 20% via CI/CD pipeline modernization and automated testing
- Drove 40% improvement in team engagement through structured mentorship and performance coaching
- Reduced AWS cloud operating costs by 15% through infrastructure sizing and architectural guidance

Professional Experience

- Senior Software Engineering Manager** Jan 2024 - Present
Thinking Bear Consulting — Los Angeles, CA (remote)
Advised organizations on architecture, delivery, and operations across media and cloud platforms
- Raised organization velocity by 20% through backlog management and Agile engineering practices
 - Identified AWS infrastructure optimizations reducing cloud operating costs by 15%
 - Authored 20+ LinkedIn articles on architecture and leadership resulting in 20% increase in followers
- Computer Science Instructor** Jul 2023 - Present
UCLA Extension — Los Angeles, CA (hybrid)
Taught Java, Data Structures, and Web Applications to working professionals and adult engineers
- Taught Java Programming, Data Structures, and Web Applications across 20 sections to 100+ students
 - Sustained a 4.7 / 5.0 instructor rating from student reviews throughout tenure
- Software Engineering Manager** Jan 2023 - Jun 2023
Brightcove — Boston, MA (remote)
Led 2 teams of 15 engineers building media management applications for 2,500+ global customers
(role eliminated during company-wide reduction in force)
- Reduced application latency by 25% and enhanced system stability through architecture refactoring
 - Resolved 75% of engineering backlog within 30 days by introducing an Agile prioritization framework
 - Boosted team engagement scores by 40% through weekly 1:1s, feedback, and growth plans
- Software Development Manager** Jan 2021 - Jun 2022
Amazon Prime Video — Culver City, CA (hybrid)
Led engineering of AWS services for global media supply chain managing 800+ licensing contracts
(role concluded following organizational restructuring)
- Increased engineering team velocity by 15% through a data-driven prioritization framework
 - Defined a 3-year engineering roadmap aligning technical investment with business priorities
 - Hired 2 engineers and promoted 2 engineers, expanding team capability and providing career pathways
 - Coordinated a security remediation rollout across 2,000+ applications completed within 1 week

Staff Software Engineer & Technical Lead

Apr 2016 - Dec 2020

NBCUniversal — Universal City, CA (on-site)

Led engineering for internal mobile and web applications supporting 23,000+ employees globally

- Redesigned push notification system, increasing engagement by 10% while reducing opt-outs by 20%
- Architected and implemented new features for mobile portal and directory, enhancing user functionality

Principal Software Engineer

May 2015 - Mar 2016

Sage — Irvine, CA (hybrid)

Led front-end development for Innovation Labs exploring new technology for financial sector

- Designed a cross-platform mobile framework adopted across 3+ enterprise products
- Authored front-end engineering standards for web and mobile applications improving code quality and long-term maintainability by 15%

Staff Research Engineer

Mar 2014 - Apr 2015

Walt Disney Studios — Burbank, CA (on-site)

Built prototypes for Technology Innovation Group that demonstrated use within studio technology

- Prototyped a digital entitlement delivery system using Bitcoin reducing entitlement delivery costs by 20%
- Developed mobile navigation prototype improving visitor directions in studio buildings by 25%

Staff Software Engineer & Technical Lead

Nov 2011 - Feb 2014

Walt Disney Studios — Burbank, CA (on-site)

Built and launched distributed media systems supporting Disney's digital distribution platforms

- Launched Disney Movies Anywhere streaming platform achieving 20M+ registered users and 3.5M mobile downloads within the first month
- Deployed high-availability streaming media infrastructure with 99.9% uptime for 4TB of content using adaptive bitrate (HLS/DASH) and DRM technologies

Senior Software Engineer & Architect

Dec 2005 - Oct 2011

Walt Disney Parks & Resorts — Glendale, CA (on-site)

Engineered reusable solutions for Disney Theme Parks website Operations and Architecture teams

- Led engineering for 12 award-winning consumer-facing websites improving performance and scalability
- Established LAMP architecture standards improving development speed and deployment reliability by 30% through automation and best practices

Education & Certifications

- **Master of Science in Computer Science** — University of California Los Angeles
- **Bachelor of Science in Computer Science** — University of Alabama
- Certified **ScrumMaster** & Certified **Scrum Product Owner** — Scrum Alliance
- Generative AI Fundamentals Certificate — Databricks
- AWS Cloud Practitioner Essentials — Amazon Web Services

Technical Skills

- **Cloud Platforms:** AWS (Lambda, ECS, S3, API Gateway), Docker, CloudFormation
- **Streaming Media Systems:** HLS, DASH, DRM (Widevine & FairPlay), CDN architecture
- **Software Development:** Java, Spring, Node.js, JavaScript, TypeScript, React, iOS, Android
- **Technical Architecture:** Microservices, Distributed Systems, REST APIs, CI/CD, DevOps, LAMP
- **Developer Tools:** GitHub, Jenkins, MySQL, Oracle, Memcached, MongoDB, Jira, Confluence